infrastructure building across all of Eurasia, designed to link land- and sea-based trade routes, running from east to west and north to south, all centered on China. Even publicity stunts are designed to strengthen images of China's economic juggernaut, exemplified by the inaugural journey of a freight train from eastern China to the United Kingdom in January 2017, which traveled twelve thousand kilometers and arrived in London to worldwide media attention.

More substantively, Chinese companies have purchased ports in Belgium, Spain, Italy, and Greece, underscoring Beijing's growing European interests. China's grasp reaches across the oceans to Africa, where it is the major builder of infrastructure and extractor of natural resources, as well as to Latin America and the Arctic. In early 2018, Beijing published its first official Arctic white paper, in which it identified itself as a "near-Arctic state," despite being no closer to the Arctic than Poland. The paper set out to identify how the Arctic region should be governed and how the OBOR initiative could be used to construct a "Polar Silk Road" linking China and Europe.[47]

Beijing's interests, however, go far beyond just the trade elements of the OBOR. Instead, it is seen as a strategic policy to expand Chinese interests abroad, gain access to strategic ports, and use trade to foster military ties. At the core of this global expansion is the country's construction industry, which builds infrastructure on every continent. In Africa and throughout Central Asia, Chinese companies are becoming increasingly ubiquitous, erecting apartment blocks, paving roads, or building port facilities. Beijing furthers its national interests by linking a military component to its development programs, in what is sometimes referred to as "debt-trap diplomacy." In Djibouti, in the Horn of Africa, for example, China has combined development aid with building its first overseas military base, which opened in July 2017. This cost of doing business with China or of accepting Chinese foreign aid often emerges only after deals have been struck, increasingly to the benefit of China's military. Sri Lanka learned this the hard way in late 2017, when it was forced to hand over control of its largest port, Hambantota, to China after it could not pay off bills to Chinese firms.[48] This gave